

to shame with his research and loves rehearsing for every shot. I, on the other hand, don't like to rehearse. I am spent if I do it. However, he knows of this shortcoming and is considerate. During *Badla* (2019), he would say to me, teasingly, "*Mohtarma, aap thoda sa rehearsal kar lijiye mere saath* [Madam, will you please oblige me with a rehearsal?]." I would hide in the other room just so that he doesn't ask me to rehearse.

I don't address Mr. Bachchan as 'Sir' in text messages. They usually begin with, 'Hey, Rockstar'. On his 80th birthday, I'd like to say to him, "Hey, Rockstar, our hat-trick is pending." ■

Taapsee Pannu has worked along side Amitabh Bachchan in Pink and Badla

Almost everyone who has worked with him credits Bachchan's long shelf-life to his discipline. And his humility. He's forever open to retakes and suggestions

personal life and anecdotes from his storied career. The show, famously, arrived at a time when Bachchan was struggling for financial security and professional relevance in a film industry that was evolving—the multiplex boom had encouraged the rise of independent cinema that deviated from formula, his old mainstay. His son, Abhishek, had made his debut with *Refugee* (2000); Shah Rukh Khan was the man of the moment, with the other Khans—Aamir and Salman—giving him a run for his money. At 59, Bachchan was very cognisant of the fact that attempting to stay the commercial Bollywood hero—as with the ill-fated *Mrityudaata*—was pointless; those days were over and he needed substantial parts that wouldn't diminish his legend. But in showbiz, out of sight equals out of mind. So playing "the friend, philosopher and guide" on *KBC* was a gamechanger, as Sameer Nair, then executive vice-president, programming, at Star Plus and a forever Bachchan fan, puts it. "When the show came on at 8 pm, the remote was controlled by parents who were Bachchan fans while the kids were fans of the Khans," notes Nair. But soon, sporting a grey French beard, seamlessly shuttling between fluent Hindi and English and exuding charm and positivity, Bachchan expanded his fan base among the young.

It was also a period when he would increase his advertising portfolio and come into contact with a new breed of creators like Shoojit Sircar and Balki, who'd later give him a gift every actor craves for: the opportunity to reinvent himself. Sircar's first film with Bachchan, *Shoebite*, hasn't yet seen the light of day, but it led to one of the most fruitful collaborations in his second inning. "We have that kind of faith in each other that we can talk about anything," Sircar once told INDIA TODAY in an interview. "I have no agenda with him and he recognises that. As a personality, he is intimidating but, inside, he is an innocent child who just wants to act."

Bachchan's talent, in this latter phase, was also very much about how he moulded it. Luck played a role, too, as a new breed of filmmakers emerged, with offbeat narratives scripted with Bachchan in mind—Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra's *Aks*, Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Black*, Balki's *Paa*, to name a few. The actor, in turn, pounced on those scripts with the same intensity he would have had for essaying Gogol's Mayor back in Sherwood College. And, in the process, he got reintroduced to a new audience. For the millennials, he wasn't "the angry young man" they had seen on satellite TV in the 1990s but the strict principal of *Mohabbatein*, the flirt of *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna*, the imposing politician of *Sarkar*, the arrogant chef of *Cheeni Kum*, the tenacious lawyer of *Pink*.


SAVINGS ACCOUNT
Enjoy ₹0 Charges
on a host of banking services like NEFT, IMPS, RTGS, etc. on your IDFC FIRST Bank Savings Account
Scan the QR code to unlock the #PowerOfMore
IDFC FIRST Bank
ALWAYS YOU FIRST
Call 1800 10 888 | IDFC FIRST Bank
T&C apply